

CHAPTER V

SCHOOL PLANTS OF DIMITT COUNTY

There are six school systems functioning in Dimitt County. These systems are the Carrizo Springs Independent School District; the Big Wells Independent School District; the Valley Wells Rural School, under the supervision of the County Superintendent of Schools; and the parochial school, "St. Thomas," at Asherton. Each one of the public school systems has a school plant for the American children and one for the Mexican children, with the exception of Valley Wells, where there is only one building. The Valley Wells District transports all its American children to Cotulla, using its school building only for Mexican children. Descriptions and photographs of each public school building appear on the following pages.

Carrizo Springs

There are two schools in Carrizo Springs. One is known as "Central Ward School," for the Americans, and the other is "East Ward School," or, as it is more commonly called, "The Mexican School."

The school building for the American children is situated in a good residential section of the city, on a high point overlooking the business section. This building consists of two stories and a basement. Ten teachers, all holding university degrees, are employed here, and special instruction is given in music, band, and art.

A fine gymnasium and a nice bank house have been built on the school grounds. The grounds are nicely landscaped with palm trees and ornamental shrubs.

After the Mexican children have passed the fifth grade, they are sent to this school, where they are isolated in one room during the sixth grade. From the seventh grade on, they are allowed to mingle with the American children.

The school plant for the Mexican children consists of three buildings which are built of tile. One building has ten rooms, and the other two buildings have two rooms each, making fourteen rooms in all. Two rooms are so constructed that they can quickly be converted into one by the use of folding doors. This arrangement provides for an auditorium when needed, as one room has a stage in one end.

This school employs fourteen teachers, of whom ten have college degrees.

The playground equipment is in good repair and is ample for the number of children. It consists of a large slide, four see-saws, a merry-go-round, and several ball diamonds.

Asherton

In Asherton, there are three school plants. One, situated in the best residential district, is for the American children. Across "Mexican Town," is another school known as the "Mexican School," where the Mexican children are segregated through the fourth grade and then are sent on to the American school. The third school is a parochial school, "St. Thomas School." This is a Catholic institution and, at present, all the pupils are Mexican children.

The Anglo-American school at Asherton is a beautiful building and is so situated as to be one of the show places of the city. It is located on high ground and avenues of palm trees lead to the two-story, white stucco building. All teachers in this school hold college degrees.

The Mexican school at Asherton consists of four rooms and is situated on the outskirts of Mexican town on a high rocky knoll where it is impossible to grow grass and shrubbery. The grounds put up a very bleak and desolate appearance. In this school system, the Mexican children are segregated through the fourth grade. When they have completed the work for that grade, they are sent to the American school. There are four teachers in the Mexican school, and each holds a B. A. degree.

Catarina

There are two schools in Catarina. One, for the American children, is situated on the main street and is a beautiful building. The other school is known as the "Mexican School" and is situated about a mile from town. The Catarina school for the Americans was built at the time of a land boom at that place. It is a very beautiful brick building, but since the land bubble burst and the town is gradually being moved away, the building is very conspicuous by way of contrast with its surroundings. It is much too large for the small number of children in attendance.

At Catarina the Mexican school consists of two small rooms. This building is located nearly a mile out of town in a very desolate place. There are no houses within a quarter of a mile. At the time the school was built, a few houses were near, but it was such an undesirable location that all the houses have been moved away. The school gives one the impression of segregation in the highest degree. The children are kept here through the fourth grade. After that they are permitted to attend the American school. Very few attend school in the higher grades. There are two teachers in this school. One has a B. A. degree, but the other teacher reports only one year of college work.

Big Wells

In the Big Wells school system, segregation is practiced through the first grade only. One building is provided for the Mexican children who have not been promoted to the second grade. From the second grade on, all children attend the American school. It is

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significant that the Mexican children coming to other schools from this school are outstanding in their command of English.

The Big Wells school is a large three-story, brick building with a beautiful lawn in front and a large football field in the back.

Big Wells has a relatively large Mexican population, and, as has been stated before, segregates through the first grade only. The building for the beginning Mexican children consists of one room and is situated several blocks from the regular city school, in the outskirts of the town. The playground is bare with very little equipment.

Valley Wells

There is only one school building in the community of Valley Wells. The Mexican children attend this school through the sixth grade. The American children are taken by bus to Cotulla. The building is a frame structure in fair condition, but the school grounds have been neglected and allowed to grow up in cactus and brush. There is a large flag pole in the front yard for which there is no flag.

The preceding information indicates that the school buildings of the Mexican children are inferior to those for the American children. The locations of the Mexican school buildings are very undesirable.

The playground equipment for the Mexican schools, with the exception of the Carrizo Springs school, is in very poor repair and, in some cases, lacking altogether. The playground equipment of the American schools is sufficient, and it is kept in good repair.

The Mexican school grounds, in every instance, present a very unpleasing appearance. There is no attempt at landscaping, except at Carrizo Springs, where a few trees and shrubs have been planted. The school grounds of the American schools, in every instance, are beautiful, with well kept lawns and shade trees.

A lunchroom is provided in only one of the school systems. This lunchroom is in the Carrizo Springs school. It is located in the gymnasium, which is nearly a mile from the Mexican school. The children walk to and from the lunchroom, except when the weather does not permit. On those occasions, a bus is sent for them. The Americans and Mexicans use the same lunchroom. The American children eat first, and the Mexican children wait until the American children are through lunch. On the way to the lunchroom there is a drinking fountain, at which the Mexican children may not drink, because of objections from the American mothers.

The only toilet facilities in the Mexican schools are outdoor privies, except in the Carrizo Springs school, where six indoor toilets and two lavatories are deemed sufficient for five hundred and seventy-five children. In every instance, in the American schools, the toilet facilities are adequate.